PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota 4Runner 2nd Gen

1990–1995 · N120 · N130

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Head-gasket history (V6)**
  Ask for paperwork. Forum owners report that trucks repaired under the V06 campaign got a label on the left front door hinge post near the check strap. Otherwise look for coolant loss, overheating, white exhaust after warm-up or a misfire on cylinder 6.
- [ ] **Timing belt on the 3VZ-E**
  The V6 is belt-driven. A 4Runners.com member recalls four years or 96,000 km as the typical interval; owners recommend an Aisin kit with the water pump. No records means do it now.
- [ ] **Frame and body rust**
  Check frame rails and crossmembers, the tailgate bottom, rear bumper and wheel arches. A rust-free body and frame is rare outside dry states, and replacement panels are hard to find.
- [ ] **Sagging rear coils**
  The four-link rear was new, but Wikipedia notes it sags too. A nose-high stance usually means tired springs; Old Man Emu sells 2 in replacement coils in two rates for these trucks.
- [ ] **Power rear window and tailgate**
  The roll-down rear glass and tailgate lock are known trouble spots — IH8MUD members say the electric rear window 'can be problematic' on both early generations. Make sure it goes up and down.
- [ ] **Four-cylinder or V6?**
  The 22R-E is slower but simpler and has no head-gasket campaign behind it; the 3VZ-E has more torque but more to go wrong. A four with a gear-driven transfer case is the stronger base for big gearing changes.
- [ ] **Front-end wear**
  On the IFS, check idler arm, tie-rod ends and CV boots, and look for a wandering steering feel on the test drive.
- [ ] **Trim and interior parts**
  Mechanical parts are easy; interior and exterior trim isn't. 4Runners.com members report even dealers struggle to supply 2nd gen trim, so a complete truck is worth more than a cheap one missing bits.

YEARS TO KNOW

1990–94	BEWARE	V6 trucks built 1/90–10/94: Toyota said its 3VZ-E head-gasket failures were primarily limited to this production window (campaign V06, expired 2018). Ask for proof of the gasket job

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Steering relay rod fatigue crack**
  1989–1995 · NHTSA 05V-389

- [ ] **Two-door**
  Built from launch to May 1993 (US sales ended August 1992, Canada through 1993). Toyota priced them above the four-door because of the chicken tax, so they are genuinely rare.

- [ ] **Pre- or post-facelift**
  1990–91 trucks have rectangular sealed-beam headlamps; the 1992-on facelift brought one-piece bumpers and modular headlamps.

- [ ] **Engine and transfer case**
  V6 (3VZ-E) trucks got a chain-driven transfer case; four-cylinder (22R-E) trucks kept the older gear-driven case.

- [ ] **Model codes**
  Toyota coded V6 trucks VZN130 and diesel trucks LN130/KZN130; the diesel, wide-body and limited-slip versions were Japanese or European, not US-market 4Runners.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/4runner/2nd-gen/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks